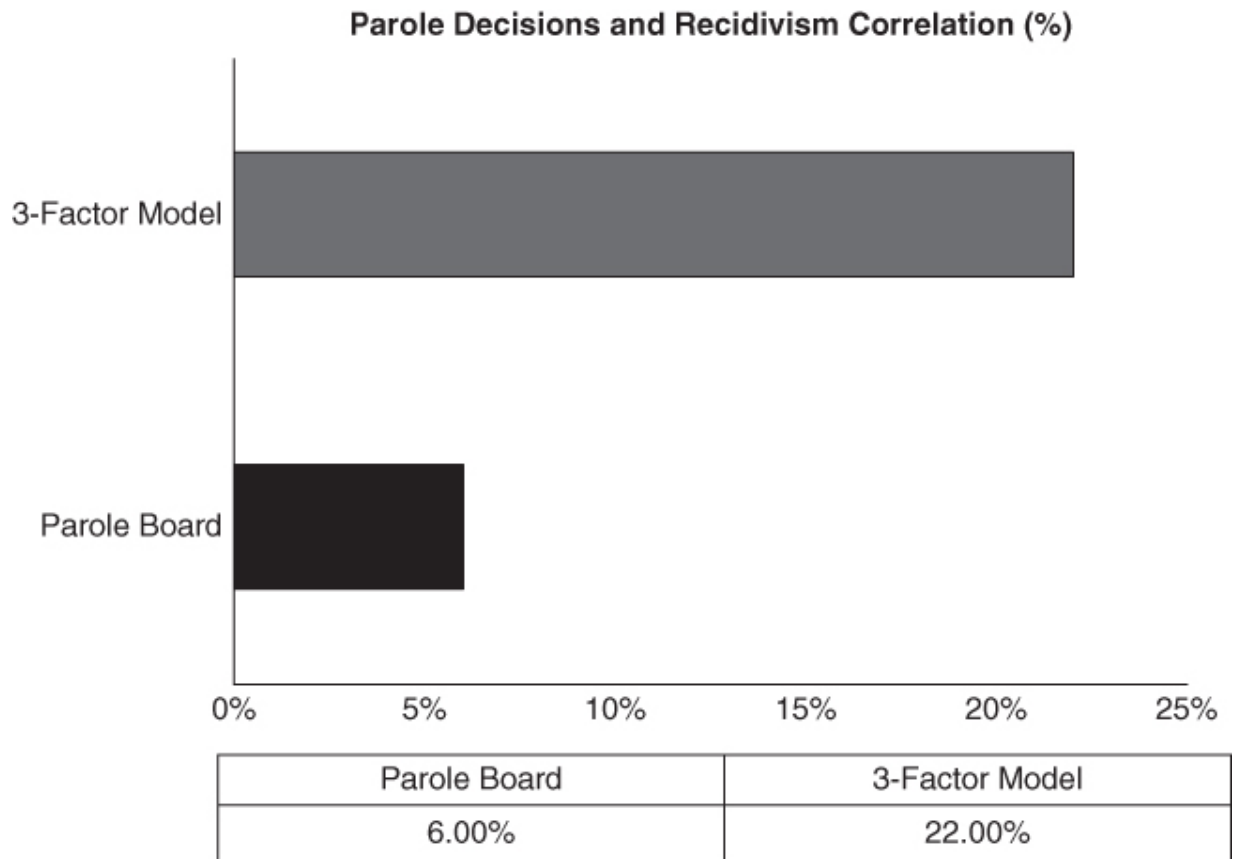


The researchers compared the performance of the “experts” versus the simple model. The summary finding is that a simple model, while far from perfect, is over *three times* more effective than experts at forecasting recidivism (see [Figure 2.1](#)).



[Figure 2.1](#) Parole Decisions and Recidivism Correlation

The research results were not lost on practitioners in the real world. A 2013 *Wall Street Journal* article, “State Parole Boards Use Software to Decide Which Inmates to Release,”⁴ highlights how algorithmic parole decisions are now the norm, and no longer the exception.

The article describes how, under budgetary pressures, many states have begun using computerized risk assessments to reduce rates of recidivism, and thus overall incarceration rates. For example, Michigan introduced computerized assessments in 2006, and by 2008 had reduced its three-year recidivism rate by 10 percent, and significantly reduced the overall prison population.